

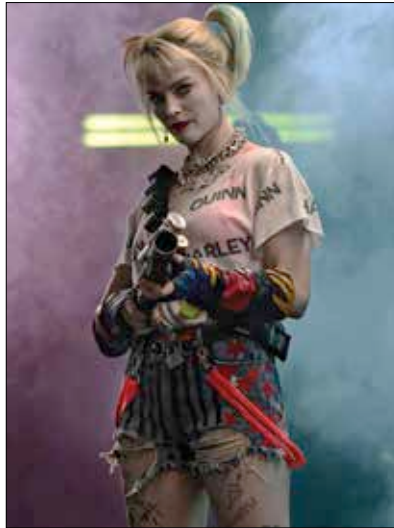
MOVIE

Birds of Prey

★★★★☆ | Directed by Cathy Yan, Harley Quinn: Birds of Prey, picks up after Harley's breakup with the Clown Prince of Crime. The pacing of the movie is good starting off with an animated short featuring her origin story and the prologue grasping the audience into the wild ride that is about to ensue.

You are introduced to a liberated version of Harley Quinn who has to stand on her own two feet in a world where everyone she has pissed off wants a piece of her. The fear of her being the "Joker's Girl" does not loom over anyone anymore. Amongst them, is Roman Sionis (Ewan McGregor) aka Black Mask, the antagonist, assisted by Victor Zsasz (Chriss Messina).

Harley is the narrator, a rather engaging one at that, and recounts the entire movie in first-person by occasionally breaking the fourth wall. By



doing so, she pulls the audience into her psyche. Her emotions, thought process, planning (barely any) and bluntness, all seem relatable thanks to the first-person perspective. You see and feel things the way Harley does. The irresponsible and delayed character descriptions add to her character as well.

'Harley's misfits' – Dinah Lance (Jurnee Smollett-Bell) aka Black Canary,

Cassandra Cain (Ella Jay Basco), Detective Renee Montoya (Rosie Perez) and Elena Bertellini (Mary Elizabeth Winstead) aka the Huntress got minimal amounts of screentime, which was disappointing. The antagonist(s) got some well-deserved character development rather than just being kept in the backdrop until it was their time to shine. Scenes shot from the back of the villains showing the impending doom added to the character depth. The fight scene edits, however, felt choppy and not in sync, at times. The use of colours and elements is brilliant.

Overall, the movie was a fun-filled experience with action. Nowhere did it feel like it was dragging or stalling for content. The pace was constant with beautiful cinematography and kept us engaged throughout. The main downsides for us were the lack of character introduction and to some level, character innovation *cough* Montoya *cough*, choppy edits, and the lacklustre soundtrack. Regardless, we would say that this movie is a positive for the DCEU.

TV SERIES

Avenue 5

★★★★☆ | At first, Avenue 5 seems like another comedic take on space travel. Instead of an exploration ship, a large number of passengers on board a luxury space liner. Hugh Laurie is the captain of the ship, and he plays the role well. He is charming, and interacts with his passengers, and everyone looks at him as a hero. He is an alcoholic unable to beat the habit, and is suffering from marital problems as well, in an appropriately futuristic three way marriage, that seems to be heading towards a trivorce. The gravity device on board the vessel suffers a malfunction, which turns into a PR nightmare for the crew. It quickly becomes a space rescue mission, to prevent the passengers from taking a ridiculously long journey through the



Solar System. The rest of the cast of characters are incredibly interesting. There is politically incorrect and always horny Mars Astronaut, who is the designated boomer on board. There is a nihilistic customer relations officer,

who acts like a therapist but seems to be doing more harm than good. Then there is a Karen who is named Karen who is launched into a redemption arc that Jamie Lannister would be proud of. Then there is the second engineer, who seems to be doing all the work and getting none of the credit. The owner of the whole organisation is also there, a man beautifully out of touch with how his company functions. This series is worth it just for all the interesting characters. There is also a very smartly written meta criticism of the format, which peeks through constantly. The satire goes more than skin deep, and deconstructs what makes such shows work, and puts them together in a unique way. Then the science is also there, all rock solid, with brief but beautiful explorations of remote solar system bodies such as Titan and Enceladus. Avenue 5 is an easy recommendation for those who like Star Trek type shows such as Another Life or The Orville.